

Macbeth I.i

William Shakespeare

1. “Man proposes, God disposes” is an example of *antithesis* from a poem by Alexander Pope. Can you find some examples in this scene? How do these antitheses emphasize the mood?
2. Opening scenes are attention-getters. As an Elizabethan stage director, how would you make this twelve-line scene engage an audience?

Macbeth I.iii

William Shakespeare

1. How can Banquo be “lesser than Macbeth, and greater,” and “not so happy, yet much happier”?
2. What does this line mean? “If chance will have me King, why chance may crown me without my stir.”
3. Some people contend that this scene goes on far too long. Consider how you might create a shorter version of it. Justify your choices.

Macbeth I.iv

William Shakespeare

1. The conversation between Duncan and Macbeth is filled with ironies. What does this conversation reveal about both Duncan and Macbeth? While Duncan may not be aware of the irony, Macbeth probably is. How, then, might he deliver his lines?

Macbeth I.v

William Shakespeare

1. Some critics argue that there are too many scenes in this act—there are seven. They contend that these scenes should not be separate but should all flow seamlessly together. Determine how you might make such an idea work on stage.

Macbeth I.vii

William Shakespeare

1. What does Macbeth's long soliloquy at the beginning of this scene mean?

Macbeth II.i

William Shakespeare

1. At what time does this scene take place? Support your inference with textual evidence.
2. What feelings does Macbeth reveal in his soliloquy at the end of this scene?

Macbeth II.ii

William Shakespeare

1. The act done, how does Macbeth feel?
2. We do not see the death of Duncan on stage. Consider why it is not included in this scene. Would you personally have chosen to include it? What difference would it make to the play if it were included? Discuss, in a multi-paragraph response, the advantages and disadvantages of either choice.

Macbeth II.iii

William Shakespeare

1. In Act I, Scene 3, Macbeth talks about “horrible imaginings.” In Act II, Scene 3, there are many of them. Make a list of all that you can find, who has them, and what their cumulative effect is on the play so far. What might they bode for the future?

Macbeth II.iv

William Shakespeare

1. Shakespeare often uses references to the weather and strange occurrences to create an ominous mood. Give examples from this scene. What do they suggest?

Macbeth III.i

William Shakespeare

1. This scene could be rather static if it were not blocked effectively. *Blocking* means figuring out how, where, and when the actors will move on stage as well as the gestures they will use so that the audience becomes involved in what is going on. Create a blocking diagram you might use for your production of this scene, along with a brief explanation of your rationale. Decide too how Macbeth will deliver the final two lines of the scene and, in a paragraph, explain your choice.

Macbeth III.iv

William Shakespeare

1. There are some fascinating images used in this scene. Make a list of the ones you find most powerful and explain how they help support the mood created during the banquet. You may have to consult the notes in the text to help you understand some of the references.

Macbeth III.v

William Shakespeare

1. Most critics believe this scene is probably not written by Shakespeare; many directors omit it altogether. Discuss why this scene might have been added. Consider the aspects that would make it popular with audiences of the time and the links it might have to the rest of the play.

Macbeth IV.i

William Shakespeare

1. There seems to be some argument about whether Act III, Scene 6 is misplaced and perhaps should come after Act IV, Scene 1. Discuss this possibility and decide the pros and cons of moving it.
2. Macbeth's utterance "Let this pernicious hour / Stand aye accursed in the calendar" is probably more prophetic than anything the witches have said. Explain the deep irony in his exclamation and what it suggests about his state of mind at this point in the play. Has he been thinking this all along or is this a sudden decision made as a result of his consultation with the witches?
3. Macbeth's soliloquy that ends this scene is significant because it reveals his current thoughts. Paraphrase this speech so you are clear about what it says and what it reveals about Macbeth's character and intentions at this time. Comment about his intended course of action and the wisdom of his decision.

Macbeth IV.ii

William Shakespeare

1. The murder of Duncan was carried out offstage. The murders in this scene are committed in front of the audience. Dramatically, what is the difference? In your production of the play, would you move these murders offstage as well? Write an explanation of your decision.

Macbeth V.i

William Shakespeare

1. Lady Macbeth seems to have instigated the actions that her husband eventually took. Why is she now so disturbed by the results of what she has done? Think back and determine her motives for Duncan's murder. Did she misjudge her husband? herself? the consequences? Look back at your earlier character sketches of this woman. In your updated portrait of Lady Macbeth, determine what kind of person you believe she really is.

Macbeth V.ii

William Shakespeare

1. Lennox ends this scene with three remarkably poetic lines (35-37). What do you think is suggested in this description? What do you make of the references to the “flower” and the “weeds”? Using these three lines, discuss the value of metaphor in conveying meaning. What, exactly, does Lennox mean, and why would he say such a thing? Why would he speak metaphorically under these circumstances? Do people normally speak this way when under pressure? How do you account for this scene’s ending?

Macbeth V.iii

William Shakespeare

1. Lines 46-52 contain an extended metaphor that conveys Macbeth's feelings that everything "weighs upon the heart." Explain that metaphor, and as the doctor, write your diagnosis of Macbeth's current state of mind. Is he curable?
2. In his soliloquy (22-31), Macbeth expresses his unhappiness about the way things have turned out for him. In your opinion, is this an accurate assessment of what his future holds? How did it get this way? Are the witches responsible for Macbeth's present situation? To what degree? Does Macbeth blame himself? What possible advice, if any, could you offer Macbeth at this stage?
3. Do you see anything at all heroic (assuming heroic to mean "noble and admirable") about Macbeth in this scene?

Macbeth V.v

William Shakespeare

1. Lines 21-30 in Scene 5 have become famous because writers frequently quote them. How do you interpret the ambiguity in the line "She should have died hereafter"? The rest of this speech focuses on time. What does Macbeth say about it, and what happened to get him to such an awareness? If you could draw a picture of "time" as Macbeth sees it, what would it look like? How would you explain Macbeth's state of mind at this time: is he frightened, exhausted, resigned, depressed, or some combination of these? Is anyone present when he utters this speech? What is the most powerful image in this speech for you? How does the image achieve this outcome?

Macbeth V.vi

William Shakespeare

1. Scene 6 contains only eleven lines. What does it accomplish in those eleven lines? Why do we need to know that Siward and his son will lead the first battle? Would you leave this scene out of your production of the play?

Macbeth V.viii

William Shakespeare

1. Some people feel that Macduff goaded Macbeth into fighting him by calling him a “coward,” much as Lady Macbeth did earlier in the play. Obviously, Macbeth does not want such a label. Why not? How do you define a coward?